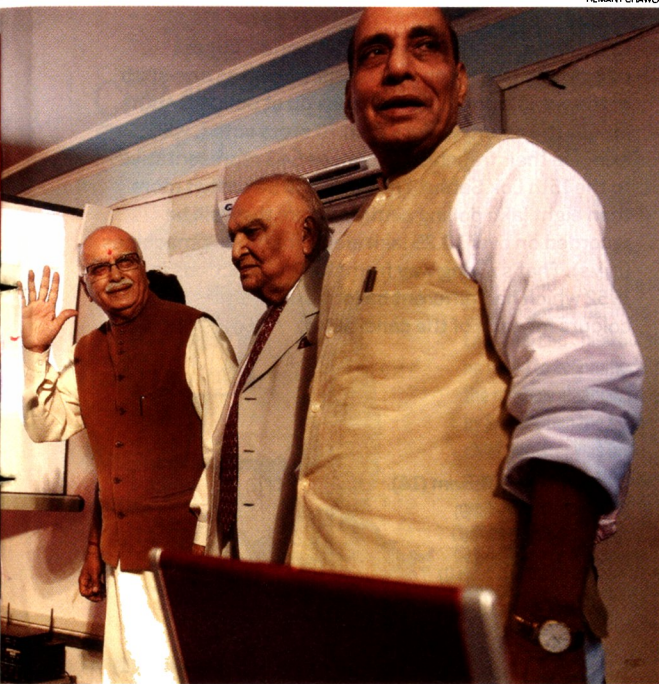




ADVANI AND RAJNATH SINGH AT THE LAUNCH OF ADVANI'S WEB PORTAL

ence, and is not sure how many votes it will translate into. "According to estimates, there are 45 million netizens in India—barely 4 per cent of the country's population. But 60 per cent of them are located in eight metros, accounting for 50 Lok Sabha seats," he explains. The website has already attracted 6,000 volunteers who are working for the party in their regions. The volunteers have also taken up initiatives like Advani@Campus and SMS campaigns. Nearly 100 bloggers have joined in by putting the Advani button on their blogs. The forum has over 7,000 members, who regularly share ideas and views about various issues affecting the country. The next step is Advani on networking sites like Orkut and Facebook.

In the first week after its launch, the website was getting about 5,000 visitors a day but soon it dwindled to 300. This is when Advani's long-time aide Deepak Chopra—an MBA—realised that even the best of products need marketing, thereby resulting in



**bjp.org**  
**25,000**  
page views per month

**pmindia.nic.in**  
**25,000**  
page views per month

**narendramodi.in**  
**22,000**  
page views per month

**cpim.org**  
**20,000**  
page views per month

is picking up dumbbells one minute and walking the digital ramp the next. The Congress says that it already has a young leader in Rahul. "Our leadership does not need gimmicks to appeal to the youth," says a Congressman.

According to Alexa, an independent body that gives traffic rankings of websites, Advani's website could witness a traffic of 50 lakh page views at its peak, which is more than what his team hopes for. The site was launched with obvious inspiration

from Barack Obama's digital presidential campaign. Conscious of Advani's age factor, his team realised that at 81, he needed an interface with the youth much more than the others. "We are not defensive about Advani's age but there was a need to project a progressive profile," says a loyalist.

It is the offline impact of the digital campaign that Advani's team is counting on even more than the online influence. Bora admits that the web campaign is aimed at a niche audi-

a tie-up with Google.

Google, however, refused to make its contract with the BJP exclusive. Shailesh Rao, MD, Google India, says that they are a non-partisan company and, if asked, would offer viable digital marketing packages to other parties too. The techno-savvy BJP has shown an impressive sense of urgency, he says. The party that has been caricatured as being steeped in mythology is leading in the cyber war for the mind and soul of India. ■